

Understand the context first.

Do this once per place, before Tool 1. It takes a few days. Skipping it is how researchers end up translating their own assumptions.

- ☐ **Set the research question, consent and deletion rules**
What you will record, who can hear it, and when it gets deleted.
- ☐ **Spend time with a local guide and varied local people**
Before any interview. Listen to how people talk to each other.
- ☐ **Notice routines, relationships, language, communication**
Who speaks first? Which language is used for what?
- ☐ **Record possible meanings and their limits**
Write down what a phrase might mean, and what you can't know yet.
- ☐ **Write your positionality note**
Below. Your language, your background, what you might mishear.
- ☐ **Build a provisional codebook, glossary and interview guide**
Provisional means it will change after Tool 2.

POSITIONALITY NOTE

Languages I speak, and how well

Where I grew up; where they grew up

What I might hear as "normal"

Words I tend to over-read

Who will help me when I don't understand

PROVISIONAL GLOSSARY • START IT HERE, CORRECT IT IN TOOL 2

WORD OR PHRASE, AS HEARD	MIGHT MEAN	CAN'T KNOW YET

NEXT PAGE **Tool 1 • Listen →**

Prime: six cue cards

READ FIRST

Read these once before the session. During it, don't interpret. Just mark what you notice with a symbol.

CARD 01

Body & posture

Opening or closing as the topic changes. Taking less space often means deference, not agreement.

→ What makes this person comfortable, or guarded?

CARD 02

Pause & silence

A long pause is data. Does it cluster around one topic? Silence may be deference, not confusion.

→ Topics that make silence are often the ones design must address.

CARD 03

Language switching

A switch mid-sentence often marks a concept that doesn't translate. Write the word exactly.

→ Which language carries the real feeling?

CARD 04

Social dynamics

Who else is in the room? A glance before answering is seeking approval. Someone answering for them is hierarchy.

→ Who else has a stake? Are they in the design?

CARD 05

Voice & tone

Faster: anxious or rehearsed. Slower: choosing words. Quieter: shame or privacy. Rising at the end: "is this right?"

→ What do they most need, or fear, from the product?

CARD 06

Objects & environment

Reaching for an object to explain something means the object may be the real interface.

→ Photograph it, with consent. Take it to Component 2.

LOG SYMBOLS

◆ Body || Pause ⇄ Switch ☉ Gaze ■ Object ↑ Voice ~ Deflect
 ✕ Avoided

NEXT PAGE **Example • Meera's interview** →

Log + Meaning Card

BLANK TEMPLATE

PARTICIPANT CODE

DATE · PLACE

LANGUAGES IN USE

WHO ELSE IS PRESENT

SYM	CUE	QUICK LOG · ≤ 3 WORDS	TRIGGERED BY
◆	Body		
	Pause		
↔	Switch		
◎	Gaze		
■	Object		
↑	Voice		
~	Deflect		
✕	Avoided		

MEANING CARD · CUT OUT, ONE PER MOMENT

SAID · IN THEIR LANGUAGE

["Form toh bhar diya, ab upar wale ki marzi."]

OBSERVED

[voice drops; looks at the floor]

INFERRED

[feels she has no control]

WHAT DID THAT MOMENT MEAN TO YOU?

["Whoever checks it. I don't know who."]

THEIR CORRECTION OR DISAGREEMENT

["upar wale" = an unknown official, not God]

NEXT **Tool 2 · Translate →**

FROM MEANING CARD NO.

LANGUAGE(S) SPOKEN

REGION

AS SAID	[in their language and script, exactly as said]
LITERAL	[word for word]
IN CONTEXT	[what was happening when it was said]
ALTERNATIVES	[other ways it could be read]
IMPLIED	[what they really meant, with tone and feeling]
SIGNALS	[arre, haaye, a laugh, a tone]
REVIEWED BY	[who checked it]

LITERAL VS IMPLIED

Literally it means [God's wish]_____, but they meant [an unknown official decides]_____.

QUESTION TO TEST IN PART B • DO OTHER PEOPLE HEAR THE SAME THING?

NEXT

Part B • Reverse thick translation →

Survey sheet • one per person

PRINT + READ ALOUD

LANGUAGES SPOKEN AT HOME

DISTRICT / REGION

CODE (NO NAMES)

Age ○ 18–24 ○ 25–40 ○ 40+ ○ I agree to take part, and to be recorded

1 Their language → meaning

SHOW THE PHRASE IN THEIR LANGUAGE

[ऊपर वाले की मर्ज़ी]

What does it say, word for word?

If someone said this to you, what would they mean?

How would they sound?

calm

worried

joking

resigned

annoyed

respectful

other: _____

2 English → their language

SHOW THE ENGLISH TEXT

[Your application is under review.]

What does this mean to you?

Say it the way you'd say it to a friend.

How would they sound?

calm

worried

joking

resigned

annoyed

respectful

other: _____

3 Standard → regional (only if relevant)

SHOW THE REGIONAL VERSION

[from your language collaborator]

Does it mean the same here?

Does it sound the same? What changes?

How would they sound?

calm

worried

joking

resigned

annoyed

respectful

other: _____

Small signals • write the word exactly

[arre, haaye, accha, a laugh, a sigh]

Researcher note • who else was present, anything odd

Tally + support check

BLANK TEMPLATE

DIRECTION 1 • THEIR LANGUAGE → MEANING	DIRECTION 2 • ENGLISH → THEIR LANGUAGE	DIRECTION 3 • STANDARD → REGIONAL
Read the implied meaning	Read the implied meaning	Read the implied meaning
Only the literal meaning	Only the literal meaning	Only the literal meaning
Something else · write it	Something else · write it	Something else · write it
What shifted?	What shifted?	What shifted?

Small signals across all sheets

["arre" × 3 · frustration; laughed × 2]

SUPPORT CHECK • TICK ALL FOUR, OR LOOP BACK

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Source language
The actual language and code-switching, not "English". | ☐ Who interpreted
None · coordinator · independent interpreter · professional. |
| ☐ Rendering
Verbatim quote · conceptual gloss · paraphrase only. | ☐ More than one source?
Did other people read it the same way, or does it rest on one person? |
- ☐ **Supported → store it**
 ☐ **Split → store with alternatives**
 ☐ **Not yet → back to Part A**

GLOSSARY ENTRY → EXPRESSION LIBRARY (TOOL 4)

PHRASE	[ऊपर वाले की मर्ज़ी]
LITERAL	[the wish of the one above]
IMPLIED	[it's out of my hands; I don't know who decides]
THE DIFFERENCE	[God → an unknown official]
SIGNALS	[resigned, a short laugh]
READ BACK BY	[8 people · 7 agree]

NEXT **Tool 3 • Test →**

Candidate wording + three lenses

BLANK TEMPLATE

HYPOTHESIS

If we say _____, then _____ will happen.

NOW • THE CURRENT WORDING

[Status: Pending]



CANDIDATE • EVERY LANGUAGE

*[Your college is checking your documents · day 3 of 15
/ आपका कॉलेज दस्तावेज़ जाँच रहा है]*

THIS AUDIENCE *[first-gen students]* using *[a shared phone]*, with *[a father]* reading it to them

N**New**

Works for someone who never filled this exact form?

✓ ✕

P**Proxy**

Works read aloud by a CSC operator or a family member?

✓ ✕

T**Trust**

Official, not scam-like? (no urgency, unofficial channel, fee)

✓ ✕

TESTED WHERE, WITH WHOM

[hostel common room, 6 students; 2 fathers by phone]

RESULT • STORE, REWRITE, OR NEW QUESTIONS

[T failed in round 1; rewrote; passed round 2 → store]

NEXT **Tool 4 • Library →**

Library entries

BLANK TEMPLATE

Print, cut out and file. Or copy the fields into a shared spreadsheet.

EXPRESSION LIBRARY • NO. ____	DESIGN LANGUAGE • NO. ____
EXPRESSION	MOMENT
LANGUAGE	REPLACES
LITERAL	ENGLISH
IMPLIED	LANGUAGE 2
HEARD WHEN	TESTED WITH
EVIDENCE	LENSES N·P·T
DON'T USE FOR	LINKED TO

EXPRESSION LIBRARY • NO. ____	DESIGN LANGUAGE • NO. ____
EXPRESSION	MOMENT
LANGUAGE	REPLACES
LITERAL	ENGLISH
IMPLIED	LANGUAGE 2
HEARD WHEN	TESTED WITH
EVIDENCE	LENSES N·P·T
DON'T USE FOR	LINKED TO

NEXT **Tool 5 • The Kahavat Relay →**

Relay sheet

BLANK TEMPLATE

IDIOM CARD _____ TOPIC _____

Fold the sheet so the next person sees only the last drawing. Never show them the idiom or the earlier lines.

ROUND 1CODE ____

Sees the idiom card

DRAW HERE

ONE LINE · YOUR LANGUAGE

ROUND 2CODE ____

Sees only drawing 1

DRAW HERE

ONE LINE · YOUR LANGUAGE

ROUND 3CODE ____

Sees only drawing 2

DRAW HERE

ONE LINE · YOUR LANGUAGE

SURVIVED

SHIFTED

from [who owns it] to

[who waits]

ADDED

DESIGN QUESTION

Does the product

assume

[one person, one phone]?

Drawings → Component 2 · Tool 2 (tag Reported) Lines → Tool 2 · Translate

NEXT PAGE **Idiom cards →**

Idiom cards

PRINT + CUT

Six Hindi examples, three blanks. **Better: collect idioms from the participants' own language** in Before you start, and check each meaning with your language collaborator. Don't explain the meaning to the first person unless they ask.

KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 एक अनार, सौ बीमार <i>Ek anaar, sau beemar</i> LITERALLY • One pomegranate, a hundred sick USUALLY MEANS • One thing, far too many people who need it. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 ऊँट के मुँह में ज़ीरा <i>Oont ke munh mein jeera</i> LITERALLY • A cumin seed in a camel's mouth USUALLY MEANS • Far too little for what's needed. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 नाच न जाने, आँगन टेढ़ा <i>Naach na jaane, aangan tedha</i> LITERALLY • Can't dance, blames the crooked courtyard USUALLY MEANS • Blaming the surroundings for your own trouble. → When has this happened to you?
KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 दूर के ढोल सुहावने <i>Door ke dhol suhaavne</i> LITERALLY • Distant drums sound sweet USUALLY MEANS • Things look better from far away. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 आसमान से गिरा, खजूर में अटका <i>Aasmaan se gira, khajoor mein atka</i> LITERALLY • Fell from the sky, stuck in a date palm USUALLY MEANS • Out of one trouble, straight into another. → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT C3 • TOOL 5 जितनी चादर, उतने पैर पसारो <i>Jitni chaadar, utne pair pasaaro</i> LITERALLY • Stretch your legs only as far as the sheet USUALLY MEANS • Live within what you have. → When has this happened to you?
KAHAVAT • FROM THE PARTICIPANTS' OWN LANGUAGE _____ _____ USUALLY MEANS _____ → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT • FROM THE PARTICIPANTS' OWN LANGUAGE _____ _____ USUALLY MEANS _____ → When has this happened to you?	KAHAVAT • FROM THE PARTICIPANTS' OWN LANGUAGE _____ _____ USUALLY MEANS _____ → When has this happened to you?